> *At an anchor in Leghorn Road ... were three seamen whipped from ship to ship ...*
>
> **POWELL,** *Weale Journal*, 1654 on "flogging round the fleet"



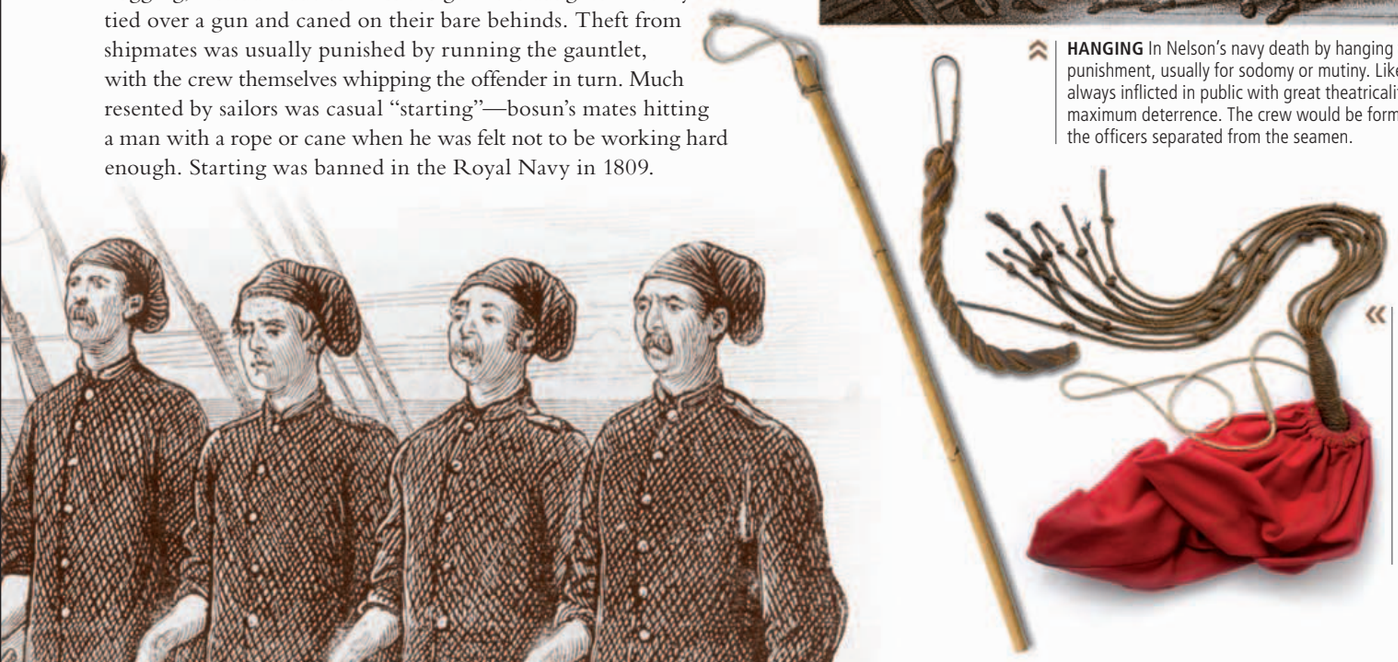
PRISON HULK After the American Revolutionary War stopped Britain offloading convicts in America, the authorities started using old warships moored offshore. The greatest use of these was made during the French Wars of 1793 to 1815 when they accommodated prisoners of war and many a French sailor was held in awful conditions.

CORPORAL AND CAPITAL

In general, though, punishments at sea have always tended to reflect the norms of the society from which the navy is drawn. For example, Britain's 18th-century navy used public corporal and capital punishment just as Britain did on land—but with less capital punishment because one could not afford to lose the men. Mutiny, treason, desertion, and sodomy were capital offences for which a man could be hanged from the yard-arm. Flogging with the cat-o'-nine tails was the punishment for many other serious offenses. It was carried out with formal ceremony, the ship's crew drawn up to watch and a roll of drums to add drama. Boys were exempt from flogging, instead made to "kiss the gunner's daughter"—they were tied over a gun and caned on their bare behinds. Theft from shipmates was usually punished by running the gauntlet, with the crew themselves whipping the offender in turn. Much resented by sailors was casual "starting"—bosun's mates hitting a man with a rope or cane when he was felt not to be working hard enough. Starting was banned in the Royal Navy in 1809.



HANGING In Nelson's navy death by hanging was the most serious punishment, usually for sodomy or mutiny. Like flogging, it was always inflicted in public with great theatricality to ensure the maximum deterrence. The crew would be formed up on deck, with the officers separated from the seamen.



CORPORAL DISCIPLINE The cane (far left) was used on the boys, the starter (center) was used to motivate the men as they performed their duties, while wayward crew members were punished by a lashing with the whip or cat-o'-nine tails (left).



CLEANING UP THE ACT

During the 19th century social norms altered away from corporal to custodial punishment. These changes were inevitably reflected at sea, although navies have often lagged behind reforms on shore. The last man in the US Navy hanged on board ship was Midshipman Philip Spencer, son of the secretary of war, allegedly guilty of mutiny in 1842. Britain's Royal Navy suspended flogging in 1881. At the same time there was more formality on board, with emphasis on saluting and minutiae of uniform. And punishments could still be harsh. The imprisonment routines of the US Navy in the "brig," including confinement on bread and water, were notoriously tough into the second half of the 20th century. The emphasis is now on "correction" rather than punishment, in line with current prison theory. Easier conditions have generally made naval service in the contemporary era a more mellow experience.